

Romeo and Juliet Act 1

SAMPSON

Gregory, on my word, we'll not carry coals.

GREGORY

No, for then we should be colliers.

SAMPSON

I mean, an we be in choler, we'll draw.

GREGORY

Ay, while you live, draw your neck out of collar.

SAMPSON

Gregory, I swear, we can't let them humiliate us. We won't take their garbage.

GREGORY

(teasing SAMPSON)

No, because then we'd be garbagemen.

SAMPSON

What I mean is, if they make us angry we'll pull out our swords.

GREGORY

Maybe you should focus on pulling yourself out of trouble, Sampson.

Notice how Shakespeare uses alliteration: (1) carry coals, which is a pun on submitting to insults and doing menial work; (2) colliers, which are coal-dealers; (3) choler, which is anger; (4) collar, which is a noose. Write a couple sentences with alliteration on today's weather.

ROMEO (taking JULIET's hand)
If I profane with my unworhiest hand
This holy shrine, the gentle sin is this:
My lips, two blushing pilgrims, ready stand
To smooth that rough touch with a tender kiss.

JULIET
Good pilgrim, you do wrong your hand too
much,
Which mannerly devotion shows in this,
For saints have hands that pilgrims' hands do
touch,
And palm to palm is holy palmers' kiss.

ROMEO
Have not saints lips, and holy palmers too?

JULIET
Ay, pilgrim, lips that they must use in prayer.

ROMEO
O, then, dear saint, let lips do what hands do.
They pray; grant thou, lest faith turn to despair.

JULIET
Saints do not move, though grant for prayers'
sake.

ROMEO
Then move not, while my prayer's effect I take.

Kisses her

Thus from my lips, by thine, my sin is purged.

JULIET
Then have my lips the sin that they have took.

ROMEO
Sin from thy lips?
O trespass sweetly urged!
Give me my sin again.

They kiss again

ROMEO (taking JULIET's hand)
Your hand is like a holy place that my hand is
unworthy to visit. If you're offended by the
touch of my hand, my two lips are standing
here like blushing pilgrims, ready to make
things better with a kiss.

JULIET
Good pilgrim, you don't give your hand
enough credit. By holding my hand you show
polite devotion. After all, pilgrims touch the
hands of statues of saints. Holding one palm
against another is like a kiss.

ROMEO
Don't saints and pilgrims have lips too?

JULIET
Yes, pilgrim—they have lips that they're
supposed to pray with.

ROMEO
Well then, saint, let lips do what hands do. I'm
praying for you to kiss me. Please grant my
prayer so my faith doesn't turn to despair.

JULIET
Saints don't move, even when they grant
prayers.

ROMEO
Then don't move while I act out my prayer.

He kisses her.

Now my sin has been taken from my lips by
yours.

JULIET
Then do my lips now have the sin they took
from yours?

ROMEO
Sin from my lips? You encourage crime with
your sweetness. Give me my sin back.

They kiss again

Argumentative Writing

The idea of sin will recur throughout *Romeo and Juliet*. Some literary scholars believe *Romeo and Juliet* is about the ramifications of sin. In this dialogue, Romeo calls himself a pilgrim and Juliet a saint. Note that pilgrims may sin, whereas saints do not sin. Note also that Juliet has already been betrothed to Paris by this moment. What does Shakespeare mean by sin? Do you think Shakespeare thinks Romeo and Juliet are sinning in this scene? If so, what kind of sin? If not, why not? Explain your answer.